

Cyber Incident Communications Packet

Ready-to-adapt internal, family, website, media, board, and recovery messages

OWNER Chief Communications Officer + Legal + Cybersecurity Coordinator	DISTRICT Ardent ISD	REVIEW CYCLE Annual + after major incident	POLICY CROSS- REFERENCE Incident Response Plan CQB
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Training Sample - Customize Before Use. This document is an instructional artifact for Ardent ISD. It should be aligned to current board policy, administrative procedures, cyber-insurance requirements, records-retention requirements, and advice of district legal counsel before operational use. Legal and reporting requirements can change.

Communications Operating Rules

- One source of truth:** Incident Lead validates technical facts; Legal validates legal statements; Communications owns publication.
- Say what is known, unknown, and being done.** Avoid speculation.
- Use the least technical language that remains accurate.**
- Never publish security details that would create additional risk.**
- Set the next-update expectation.** Silence invites rumor.
- Keep versions.** Preserve every published statement and approval record.

A. Initial Staff Leadership Alert

Subject: Cybersecurity Incident - Leadership Awareness

Ardent ISD is responding to a cybersecurity incident involving **[system/vendor]** discovered at **[date/time]**. Technology Services has **[contained/restricted/isolated]** the affected service and is working with district leadership, legal counsel, and cybersecurity partners.

At this time, **[brief verified operational impact]**. Staff should continue normal operations except for **[specific instruction]**.

Please do not speculate about the incident or share screenshots, logs, or unverified information. Direct media or public inquiries to Communications. Report any related suspicious activity to **[internal reporting channel]**.

Next leadership update: **[date/time]**.

B. Districtwide Staff Notice

Subject: Important Technology Security Update

Ardent ISD is investigating a cybersecurity incident involving **[service]**. We have taken steps to contain the issue and are working with appropriate cybersecurity and legal resources.

What staff need to do now:

- **[Action 1: e.g., do not use service until notified]**
- **[Action 2: e.g., complete password reset through official portal]**
- **[Action 3: report unexpected MFA prompts or suspicious messages]**

Do not send passwords, student information, screenshots of security tools, or incident details through ordinary email or public AI tools.

We will provide another update by **[date/time]**.

C. Family Holding Statement

Ardent ISD is investigating a cybersecurity incident involving **[system/vendor]**. The district has taken steps to contain the incident and is working with cybersecurity and legal professionals to determine the scope. **[Instructional/operational status]**.

If our investigation shows that a student's information was involved in a way that requires notification, the district will contact affected families directly with verified details and recommended next steps. Updates will be posted at **[district incident page]**.

D. Website Notice

Cybersecurity Incident Update - [Date]

Ardent ISD is responding to a cybersecurity incident discovered on **[date]** involving **[service]**. The district has contained **[known condition]** and continues to investigate.

Current service impact: [plain-language status]

Information impact: [known data categories, or "under investigation"]

What families/staff should do: [specific action or "no action requested at this time"]

Next update: [date/time]

The district will update this page when there is meaningful new information.

E. Media Holding Statement

Ardent ISD is responding to a cybersecurity incident involving **[system]**. We have taken containment steps and are working with cybersecurity professionals and legal counsel. Our priority is protecting students, staff, and continuity of district operations. Because the investigation is active, we will not speculate about cause or scope. We will share verified information when appropriate and will make required notifications.

Media Q&A Guardrails

Question	Recommended approach
Was this ransomware?	Answer only when confirmed. If unknown: "The investigation is ongoing; we are not characterizing the incident beyond verified facts."
Was data stolen?	Distinguish "accessible/viewed/copied/exfiltrated" only when evidence supports the term.
Who attacked you?	Do not attribute unless law enforcement/forensics has validated and leadership authorizes.
Did you pay a ransom?	Refer to superintendent/legal; do not answer casually.
Why wasn't this prevented?	Explain layered risk management and current remediation; do not blame an employee/vendor before review.
How many people are affected?	Use validated count and clarify whether "potentially affected" or confirmed.

F. Board Update Email

Subject: Confidential Cyber Incident Update - AISD-IR-[ID]

Board Members,

Ardent ISD is responding to a cybersecurity incident discovered **[date/time]**. Current verified facts:

- affected service(s): [];
- operational impact: [];
- data impact: [];
- containment status: [];
- outside partners engaged: [];
- required notifications: [].

The administration's immediate priorities are **[containment, legal reporting, continuity, recovery]**. The next update will be provided **[date/time]**. Please direct external inquiries to the Superintendent/Communications so the district can provide consistent, verified information.

G. All-Clear / Recovery Message

Ardent ISD has restored **[service]** following the cybersecurity incident first reported on **[date]**. The district has completed the immediate containment and recovery work required to return the service to normal operation. Additional security improvements and post-incident review will continue.

What changed:

- [control/remediation];
- [user action];
- [vendor/system change].

Thank you for following district instructions during the response. Staff should report any unusual activity through the normal technology support/security channel.

H. Parent FAQ - AISD-IR-2026-004 Sample

Was my child's password exposed?

No. In this sample incident, the affected portal did not store district passwords.

Was my child's Social Security number exposed?

No. The affected portal did not contain Social Security numbers.

Why are you notifying me?

The district's investigation found that protected student information may have been viewed by an unauthorized person. Ardent ISD is providing notice consistent with its obligations and commitment to transparency.

Do I need to freeze my child's credit?

Based on the sample data involved, the district is not recommending that step at this time. If the investigation changes the risk assessment, the district will update families.

Why can't you tell us exactly who did it?

Attribution requires reliable evidence and may involve law enforcement. Publishing speculation can interfere with the investigation and create misinformation.

Approval Record

Version	Date/time	Technical fact check	Legal review	Communications approval	Published where
1.0					
1.1					

References

- CISA - #StopRansomware Guide
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist
- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Security Breach Notification and Response